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It is about a man and a woman who are in love, and who sacrifice love for a higher purpose.

**Roger Ebert**

*Chicago Sun-Times, 1996*

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deeply poignant moment. While the audience longs for the romance to endure, it recognizes that nobility must win the day.

### Enduring appeal

When Rick tells Ilsa, “You’re getting on that plane with Victor where you belong,” the audience vicariously shares his heroism and her self-denial—basking in the reflected glory of renouncing romantic love

**Actors Henreid, Bogart,** and Bergman did not know, until the final day of shooting, who would get on the plane. This uncertainty contributed to the emotional ambivalence of Bergman’s performance.

for the greater good. Clearly a powerful message at the time of the movie’s release, it has not lost any of its power over the years. Indeed, audiences today may be tempted to look back on a better, albeit fictional, world, in which personal gratification appeared less likely to prevail over the common cause, while the on-screen chemistry of the movie’s stars enhances the viewer’s pleasure at identifying with them.

However, the movie’s appeal does not lie in the passion and selflessness of its leads alone. It has a strong cast of minor characters, including a black-marketeer played by Peter Lorre and a police chief by Claude Rains. Both play morally ambiguous roles in a corrupt world, yet are ultimately redeemed along with cynical, hard-drinking Rick. ■



### Humphrey Bogart Actor

Humphrey Bogart was renowned for playing world-weary outsiders with a noble streak. Born on Christmas Day 1899 to a wealthy New York family, he had a privileged, if lonely, childhood. He served in the US Navy during World War I, after which he struggled for a decade to establish his acting career before finally making a name for himself playing gangsters and villains in Hollywood B-movies. His big breakthrough came when he played the damaged hero in *The Maltese Falcon*. A string of great movie roles followed, including *To Have and Have Not*, *The Big Sleep*, and *Key Largo* (1944), with his wife Lauren Bacall. *The African Queen* won Bogart his only Academy Award, for Best Actor, in 1951. He appeared in more than 75 movies over a 30-year career and died, at 57, in 1957.

### Key movies

**1941** *The Maltese Falcon*  
**1944** *To Have and Have Not*  
**1946** *The Big Sleep*  
**1951** *The African Queen*